price for a gram is Rs 1,000-Rs 3,000, which makes it among the most expensive narcotics in the market right now. It is also highly addictive. "Alcohol takes years to get addicted to, drugs take days," says Ajit Pawar, a Mumbai-based addiction therapist who regularly sees patients from Gujarat. Drug addiction is more rampant than alcoholism, he claims. MD addiction is also lethal. "It kills in 2.5-3 years."

Mephedrone is a drug that was banned in India in 2015 under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances or the NDPS Act (see *MD: A Fact Sheet*). However, both producing it and consuming it are easy. To begin with, most of the 8-10 chemicals used as raw materials can be procured over-the-counter. MD doesn't need any of the seven chemicals that the NCB controls under the NDPS Act. While these seven chemicals are legitimately used in many industries such as dyes, printing and pharma, they also find illegitimate use in the production of semi-synthetic drugs such as heroin. However, they are so heavily controlled that it's not easy to traffic them. Enter MD. Investigating agencies have demanded that similar rules be put in place for MD chemicals, but pharma and allied industries have resisted it, claiming that such restrictions and allied expenditures reduce their competitiveness.

That apart, MD's manufacture does not require much equipment, even an average chemist can prepare it in a jiffy. The instructions for the process can be found online. However, the very simplicity of manufacturing leaves it susceptible to spurious content. Gujarat is the hub of API (Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients) manufacturing in the country. The abundance of dilapidated factory units in industrial belts gives MD manufacturers excellent cover, with even temporary sheds enough for their clandestine pursuits. "It is so rudimentary that they can see police teams approach from a distance and escape," says a police officer. And the profit margin is on the order of 10 times. As a source from the NCB reveals, "The manufacturing price of a kilogram of MD is Rs 10,000. The street price is Rs 10 lakh per kilogram."

Local manufacture apart, ready-to-sell MD also comes to Gujarat from Pratapgarh, Barmer and Sanchore in Rajasthan, and from Mumbai. "Though it is not yet clear whether there is an international syndicate or cartel behind it, we are treating this as organised crime," says Deepan Bhadran, deputy inspector general of police, Gujarat ATS. MD manufactured in Gujarat, on the other hand, finds its way to Punjab, Mumbai, Delhi and Dubai.

Manufacturers also plug into the sales network of drug traffickers who are doing time in jail. Peddlers and suppliers are often connected through a stealth network and may not be familiar with each other. In some isolated cases, the dark web is also used. Then there are the 'carriers', or people

ALL IN A YEAR

April 2022

- Special Operations Group arrested two men from Rajasthan in Ahmedabad with MD worth over Rs 23 lakh

July 2022

- A 32-year-old woman is caught selling MD in Ahmedabad worth Rs 1.55 lakh

August 2022

- The Anti-Narcotics Cell of the Mumbai Police raids a manufacturing unit in Ankleshwar, seizing 513 kg of MD worth Rs 1,026 cr. The bust is linked to Mumbai's Nalasopara raid earlier in the month
- The Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) raids a manufacturing unit in Moksi village near Vadodara. As much as 225 kg of MD worth Rs 1,125 crore is recovered from the under-construction factory
- Four arrested with MD worth Rs 29 lakh by the Ahmedabad Crime Branch

October 2022

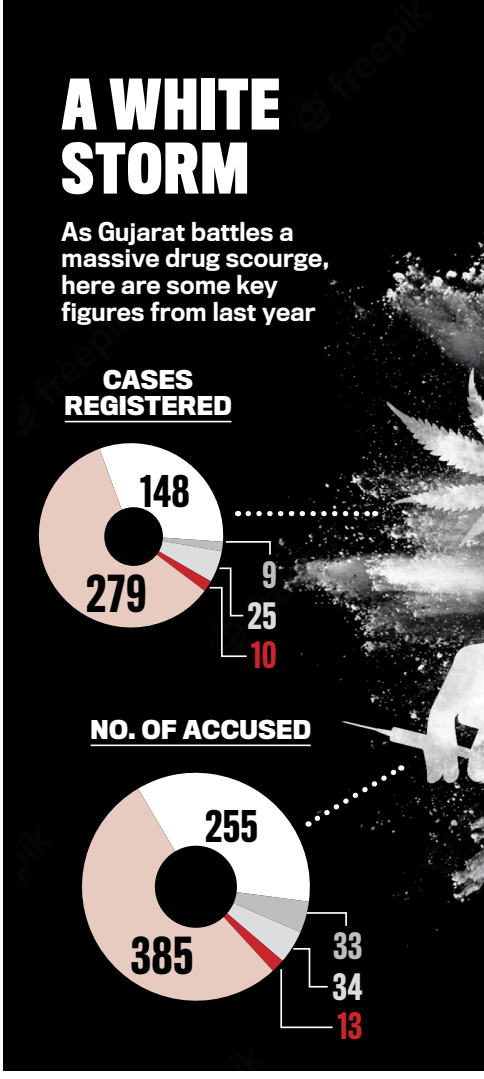
- The Narcotics Control Bureau conducts a raid in Jamnagar after a raid in Mumbai, and seizes over 60 kg of MD worth Rs 120 crore
- Mother, son arrested with MD worth Rs 1.67 crore in Surat

November 2022

- ATS raids a manufacturing unit in Sindhrot near Vadodara and seizes a huge cache of MD and raw materials worth Rs 479 crore

December 2022

- ATS recovers MD worth over Rs 120 crore in Vadodara



Source: Office of DGP, Gujarat